



The Bottom Line

This mostly-true spoof was published in the now-defunct “Refund Express” newsletter in 1996, shortly after I’d given birth to our sixth child. I used that same coupon box up until May of 2011. The station wagon is long gone. So are the jeans.

ROMANCE IN AISLE 3

She entered the store with a spring in her step, her first lone outing since the baby was born. She’d taken great care with her appearance. The daily walks had paid off, and she was finally able to get back into her jeans, albeit lying down on the bed to zip them up. The waistband cut painfully into her protruding belly and she winced every time she bent over, but didn’t they say that beauty hurt? The baby was asleep, the sun was out, and she had one glorious hour in which to peruse the grocery store aisles before her husband left for work. Just the fact that she was dressed, in makeup, and out the door before 8:00 a.m. was a miracle in itself. But with her well-organized coupon box and grocery list in hand Mary felt as though she could conquer the world today. She felt the familiar rush of adrenaline as she approached the produce section. Bags of overripe bananas lined the shelves and were marked at 39¢ each. Two bags went into her cart.

It was in Aisle 1 that she noticed him. A young man was filling his cart from the display of Pepsi at the end of the aisle. As she walked by,